

Week 11: The morphology-syntax interface

English Morphology

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Valency and arguments

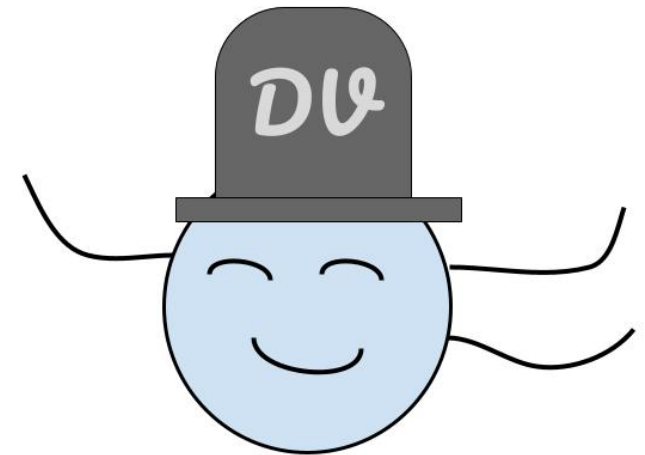
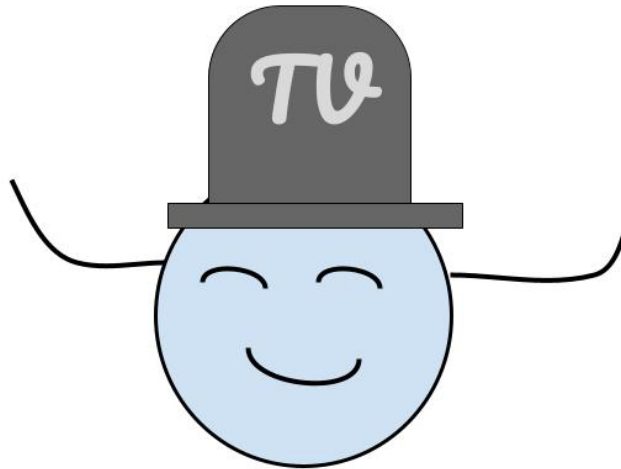
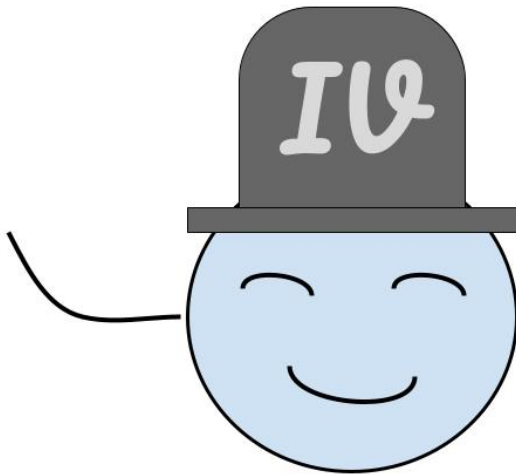
Valency

Number of arguments that a verb takes.

- Note that **argument** is a **semantic** concept, whereas **subject**, **object** and **adjunct** are **syntactic** concepts.
- Arguments are **phrases that are semantically necessary for a verb**, or are implied by the meaning of the verb.

Verbs according to transitivity

- Verbs that have only one argument are **intransitive**.
Ex: snore
- Transitive verbs require two arguments: a subject and an object.
 - Ex: discuss
- Sometimes, a verb will require three arguments. They are called ditransitive verbs.
 - Ex: give



Are arguments obligatory?

- Some arguments are not mandatory (though they often are).
- Example: eat
 - *I'm eating.* ✓
 - *I'm eating a pizza.* ✓
- Note that prepositional phrases are not necessary to the meaning of the verb, therefore they are not arguments. Syntactically speaking, these are **adjuncts**.
- However, languages have -to different extents- morphological mechanisms to change the valency of the verb
- This way, we can e.g. **turn a transitive verb into an intransitive one**, or vice versa.

Passivization

- In active sentences, the subject of the sentence is the agent:

Agent = subject

Patient = object

The government lifted the ban.

- ...whereas in the passive sentence we don't need the agent.

Patient = subject

(Agent = adjunct)

The ban was lifted (by the government).

Anti-passive

- The anti-passive also reduces the number of arguments of the verb. However, instead of eliminating the agent, what disappears is **the patient**.
- The argument made optional can also be expressed explicitly, but in different case
 - In anti-passive sentences, the subject is absolutive and the object, when expressed, goes in dative or locative case

Yidiñ (Dixon 1977: 279)

yɪŋu buŋa buga-:dɪŋ
this.ABSOLUTIVE woman.ABSOLUTIVE eat-ANTIPASSIVE
‘This woman is eating’

wagu:də wawa-:dɪŋu gudaga-nda
man.ABSOLUTIVE saw-ANTIPASSIVE dog-DATIVE
‘The man saw the dog’

Causatives

- Causatives add a new argument: the subject, which is the causer of the action
- Note that ‘boil’ has only one (patient) argument, to which the causer is added
- In the second example, the verb has two arguments, to which a third one is added.

Vitale (1981: 158)

- a. maji ya-me-chemka
water it-PER-boil
‘The water boiled’
- b. Badru a-li-chem-sh-a maji
Badru he-PST-boil-CAUSE water
‘Badru boiled the water’ (lit. ‘caused the water to boil’)

Vitale (1981: 156)

- a. Halima a-li-ki-pika chakula
Halima she-PST-it-cook food
‘Halima cooked the food’
- b. Juma a-li-m-pik-ish-a Halima chakula
Juma he-PST-her-cook-CAUSE Halima food
‘Juma caused Halima to cook food’

Applicative

- Applicative morphology adds an object to the valency of the verb.

Vitale (1981: 44); Baker (1988: 393)

a. ni-li-pika chakula

I-PST-cook food

‘I cooked some food’

b. ni-li-m-pik-i-a chakula Juma

I-PST-for him-cook-APPL food Juma

‘I cooked some food for Juma’

Noun Incorporation

- Some languages (usually polysynthetic ones) may allow for the Incorporation of a noun as part of the verb

Baker and Fasola (2009: 595)

- a. Ñi chao kintu-le-y ta chi pu waka
my father seek-PROG-IND.3SG.SBJ the COLL cow
'My father is looking for the cows'
- b. Ñi chao kintu-waka-le-y.
my father seek- COW-PROG-IND.3SG.SBJ
'My father is looking for the cows'

Clitics

- Clitics are neither affixes nor free morphemes:
 - They don't bear stress
- They form one single phonological word with an adjacent word (host)
- 'll is the contracted form of *will*, and 'd the contraction of *would*.
- Note that these may also attach to other word categories:
- Clitics may appear before or after the host
 - Proclitics come **before** the host
 - Enclitics come **after** the host

Simple and special clitics

- In English, forms such as *'ll* or *'d* are examples of simple clitics, which are unaccented variants of free morphemes and appear in the same position as the free word would
- **Special clitics** also depend on a host, but they are not reduced forms of independent words. Though it may appear written apart from the host, they cannot form a phonological word.

a. Je vois Pierre.

I see Pierre.

b. Je le vois.

I him see.

c. *Je vois le.

I see him.

Phrasal verbs

- In English, phrasal verbs consist of a verb and a preposition:
 - call up
 - put down
 - chew out
- They tend to have idiomatic meanings
- However, they are not compounds, since verb and prepositions may not appear together (one after another)
 - I called my friend up.

Phrasal compounds

- Compound consisting of phrase + noun:
 - stuff-blowing-up effects!
 - take-it-or-leave-it stance

Morphological vs. syntactic expression

- Some languages may express things morphologically, which means they deploy inflection or derivation mechanisms to convey meaning
- Ganar-e-mos
- win-FUT-1.PL
- Other languages, while still being able to convey the same meaning, might have to do so periphrastically: English *We will win* is the equivalent of *Ganaremos*

Summary

- Morphology and syntax are not fully independent from each other
- Morphology may affect the syntax of a sentence by changing the valency of the verb
- Some phenomena may blur the line between morphology and syntax, such as clitics, phrasal verbs, and phrasal compounds
- Some languages may have several mechanisms that allow for morphological expression of meaning, while others do so periphrastically

Next week

- Finish exercises
- Attend your tutorial